

Portugal 2026 - Dining: the full universe

Everything we considered, what made the cut, and why - per location. For family review.

This is the long list we started from and the set we landed on, so you can see the logic and reinstate / swap / reprioritize anything. The final picks (with live menu links) are in the separate dining sheet.

PICK = first choice | **BACKUP** = ranked fallback | **KEPT** = in the lineup | **CUT** = considered but dropped. Filters applied to everything below: **a la carte** (no 3-4hr tasting menus), genuinely good **vegetarian** options, **authentic Portuguese or high-end ethnic** (not bland western), high-end food but **casual**, works for a **table of 9** incl. kids, ~7pm, ~\$100pp ceiling.

Sintra / Cascais — 1 dinner (Sat Jul 25)

Option	Verdict	Why
Mare - Jose Avillez <i>Cascais - Portuguese seafood</i>	PICK	By Jose Avillez (Portugal's most celebrated chef); in the Michelin Guide. A la carte fish & seafood PLUS meat dishes (sirloin, veal) and real veg small plates; ocean terrace, 'sophisticatedly relaxed,' two rooms + terraces seat 9. Hits authentic + casual + non-seafood + veg all at once.
Arola <i>Penha Longa (on-resort) - tapas</i>	BACKUP	Sergi Arola's creative tapas, right at the hotel = zero drive after the red-eye. Shareable, kid-friendly, easy.
Midori <i>Penha Longa - Japanese (1 Michelin star)</i>	CUT	Superb, but now TASTING-MENU ONLY (7-course EUR154 / 9-course EUR186): breaks a la carte + the ~\$100 ceiling + 'no 3-4hr sittings,' and only 6 tables (a 9-top is near impossible).
LAB by Sergi Arola <i>Penha Longa - 1 Michelin star</i>	CUT	Fine-dining tasting format; not the casual a la carte evening we want with the kids.
Cantinho do Avillez / Monte Mar / Mar do Inferno <i>Cascais</i>	CUT	Fine, but weaker veg and unnecessary once Mare + Arola cover the night.

Algarve — 5 dinners (Sun-Thu Jul 26-30), all on-resort at Pine Cliffs

Option	Verdict	Why
Rohini by Little Miss India <i>Indian - the veg anchor</i>	KEPT	On-resort Indian with abundant genuine vegetarian dishes + cultural dinner nights (music/dance). The best night of the trip for our vegetarian. (Seasonal pop-up - confirming it runs our dates.)
Yakuza by Olivier <i>Japanese</i>	KEPT	One of the Algarve's top Japanese tables (chef Olivier da Costa); a la carte, open-air, strong veg sushi/tempura. Relaxed and informal.
O Pescador <i>seafood</i>	KEPT	Among the best seafood on the resort/coast; fresh-caught fish, contemporary beach setting.
Mare at Pine Cliffs <i>casual Portuguese</i>	KEPT	Beachfront over Praia da Falesia: fresh seafood PLUS grilled fish & meats + Mediterranean - covers the non-seafood eaters. The easy night.
Piri Piri Steak House / repeat favorite <i>flex 5th night</i>	KEPT	A meat-forward option, or simply repeat whichever of the four the table loved most.

Option	Verdict	Why
Olhos de Agua walkables: La Cigale (since 1960), O Manuel, Passaro Azul <i>village seafood, walkable</i>	CUT	Genuinely authentic Portuguese seafood - BUT the vegetarian is left with 'vegetable lasagne, pizza or salad' (fails the real-veg rule). Stayed on-resort for better veg + no night driving with the 3-yo.
Vila Joya (2*) / Ocean @ Vila Vita (2*) / Gusto by Heinz Beck <i>Algarve fine dining</i>	CUT	World-class, but formal fine-dining / tasting menus (and Gusto is Italian-western) - break the casual + a la carte + cuisine rules and the budget.
Vilamoura / Almancil drive-out spots <i>15-40 min away</i>	CUT	To get good veg + non-seafood you'd have to drive out; breaks 'easy there and back.'

Lisbon — 2 dinners (Fri Jul 31 Portuguese, Sat Aug 1 ethnic)

Option	Verdict	Why
Bairro do Avillez - Pateo <i>Chiado - Portuguese (Jul 31)</i>	PICK	By Jose Avillez; lively courtyard hall, a la carte Portuguese (seafood, fish, meat, desserts) made for sharing. Genuinely family-friendly, open nightly, seats 9; a pizzeria + tavern share the same roof for the kids/veg.
Prado <i>Mouraria - farm-to-table (Jul 31)</i>	BACKUP	Michelin Guide + Repsol Sol. Daily-changing modern Portuguese, 'many vegetarian options,' good for groups - the strongest veg of the Portuguese options.
Ibo <i>Cais do Sodre - Mozambican/Goan (Aug 1)</i>	PICK	Acclaimed riverfront Mozambican-Goan: crab curry, lamb xacuti, Mozambican prawns - PLUS many real veg options. Capacity 76 (9 is easy), sunset river views, open Saturdays.
Sabores de Goa <i>Anjos - Goan (Aug 1)</i>	BACKUP	Authentic Goan/Indo-Portuguese, proven with big family groups (16-20), strong veg + pescatarian.
Zafran <i>Saldanha - refined Indian (Aug 1)</i>	BACKUP	Often called Lisbon's best Indian; an India-Mozambique-Portugal route, more elevated, with a vegetarian tasting option.
Encanto <i>Jose Avillez - vegetarian</i>	CUT	Fully vegetarian and acclaimed - but TASTING-ONLY (~EUR155) with no kids menu: breaks a la carte + kids + budget.
Belcanto <i>Jose Avillez - 2 Michelin stars</i>	CUT	The flagship fine-dining tasting; formal + pricey, wrong vibe for a table of 9 with kids.
Cervejaria Ramiro <i>famous seafood/shellfish</i>	CUT	Legendary - but it's a shellfish temple; poor for a lifelong vegetarian.
Time Out Market (for dinner) <i>food hall</i>	CUT	Cut as a DINNER - kept for LUNCH instead (easy food hall, something for everyone incl. veg).

Draft for family input - tell us anything you'd reinstate, cut, or reprioritize and we'll re-rank.